

Scam Spotters



BIG IDEA Scams try to rush you or tempt you. SPOT the signs, then Pause, Check, Tell.

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: Scam Sort Cards (R-3.1; half-deck of 18 per group), three mats (SCAM, REAL, PAUSE-AND-ASK), SPOT poster (R-0).

- ☐ Cut the cards: Half A is 1 to 18, Half B is 19 to 36.
- ☐ Lay out the three mats for each group.
- ☐ Hang the SPOT poster: Secrets asked, Pressure, Offer too good, Trick to move you.

1 HOOK 2 MIN *60-second script* “Detectives, quick quiz. Priya got a message in a game: ‘WINNER! You get 10,000 free coins! Click now before it ends in 10 minutes!’ What should she do? (*Take 2 or 3 answers.*) Priya did what a Scam Spotter does. She did not click. She said, ‘Hmm, who made this? Why is it rushing me?’ She showed her mom and they checked the real game store together. No free coins. It was a scam. Scammers do not need to be clever. They just need you to rush. So we need a checklist that slows us down. It spells SPOT.”

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN *The Great Scam Sort*

- 1 (1 min) Teach SPOT with motions.** S: finger to lips. P: tap watch. O: hands wide. T: finger traces an arrow.
- 2 (1 min) Model one card:** “Free coins, click here fast.’ An Offer too good, Pressure and a Trick. Three SPOT signs. SCAM pile.”
- 3 (5 min) Group sort.** One reader at a time. SCAM, REAL or PAUSE-AND-ASK? Write a SPOT letter on every scam card. If unsure, PAUSE-AND-ASK is a good answer.
- 4 (1 min) Reveal and tally.** Celebrate PAUSE-AND-ASK as a smart choice.

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1** “Why do scams use hurry words?” (They want you to act before you think.)
- 2** “How can you check if something is real?” (Ask a grown-up; open the official place yourself.)
- 3** “Is it okay to feel tempted by a free offer?” (Yes. SPOT helps.)

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “A message that feels too good, pushy or secret is a hackles-up moment. If you clicked anyway, it is never your fault. One SPOT sign means Pause. Check at the real place or with a grown-up. Tell, even if you already clicked. Say it twice, whisper then strong: ‘No thanks. I’m checking with my grown-up.’”

Hand signal: The SPOT motions (lips, watch, hands wide, arrow), then Hackles Up and Pause, Check, Tell.

EXIT TICKET “Draw or write one SPOT sign you will watch for.”

FUN BOOST SPOT in Motion (30 seconds). Call a letter and everyone does its sign. Call hurry words (“Hurry!” = P, “Free!” = O) and speed up.

LEVEL-UP Silliest Scam. Write a scam so silly nobody could fall for it (“FREE DRAGON! Just send me your lunch!”) and mark its SPOT signs.

DIFFERENTIATE Use 12 cards (3 per family) and color the SPOT letters; pair with a reading buddy.

FAMILY CARD Ask your child to show you the SPOT hand signs. Nothing legitimate asks a child for a password, code or gift card.

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

- **Say:** “Thank you for telling me. You did the right thing.”
- “Scammers are good at tricking people. It is never your fault.”
- “I can’t keep this a secret, because I need to get you help. I will tell you who I tell.”
- **Do not say:** “I promise I won’t tell anyone.”
- “How could you fall for that?”
- Anything beyond “Can you tell me more?”

First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: tell your counselor or designated person right away. Follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law.